

Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: Tuesday at 9:00 a.m.	**Entry:** 1
Description	A phishing email with a malicious attachment, allowed hackers to deploy ransomware causing a small U.S. health care clinic to have its files encrypted. This caused major disruptions in their business operations.
Tool(s) used	None
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? An unethical hacker group • **What** happened? Ransomware was deployed • **When** did the incident occur? Tuesday at 9:00 a.m. • **Where** did the incident happen? A small U.S. health care clinic • **Why** did the incident happen? Phishing emails installed malware on employee computers
Additional notes	What did this email include and why did the employee download the files in the email.

Date: Wednesday, July 20, 2022	**Entry:** 2
Description	An alert was received for a suspicious file being downloaded on an employee's computer. An employee received a phishing email and opened the file which executed a malicious payload.
Tool(s) used	SHA256 and the VirusTotal website
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? A malicious hacker • **What** happened? A malicious payload was executed on an employee computer • **When** did the incident occur? At 1:13 p.m. the file was downloaded • **Where** did the incident happen? At a financial services company • **Why** did the incident happen? A phishing email tricked an employee to download the file.
Additional notes	This file has been identified as malicious and there are many indicators. Using VirusTotal I found that 57/72 security vendors have flagged this file as malicious. This is a very high number which is more likely to be malicious. The file also has a -292 community score and having a negative community score further shows that this file is malicious. The final check I made on VirusTotal was the security vendors' analysis which shows that the majority of the detections for this file have malicious flags indicated by the red exclamation marks. The conclusion of my search shows that this file is indeed malicious.

Date: December 28, 2022 at 7:20 p.m.	**Entry:** 3
Description	An individual was able to gain unauthorized access to customer PII and financial information using a vulnerability found in the e-commerce web application. Approximately 50,000 customer records were affected.
Tool(s) used	None
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? Malicious attacker • **What** happened? A forced browsing attack was used to gain access to customer transaction data. • **When** did the incident occur? December 22, 2022 • **Where** did the incident happen? Mid-sized retail company • **Why** did the incident happen? There was a vulnerability in the e-commerce website.
Additional notes	This incident caused the company $100,000 in direct costs and potential loss of revenue.

Date: March 25, 2026	**Entry:** 4
Description	Exploring signatures and logs with Suricata
Tool(s) used	Suricata

The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? N/A • **What** happened? N/A • **When** did the incident occur? N/A • **Where** did the incident happen? N/A • **Why** did the incident happen? N/A
Additional notes	Using suricata allowed me to create rules for packets that pass though the interface as well as view and monitor the logs. Using the action component of the rule lets you choose what will happen if all conditions are met. Some options that can be used are to alert, drop, pass or reject the packet. The header component of the rule decides the source and destination, ip addresses, ports and traffic direction. Finally the rule options component lets you add any extra parameters. You can add a message to alerts, or identify the signature version.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	**Entry:** Record the journal entry number.
Description	Provide a brief description about the journal entry.
Tool(s) used	List any cybersecurity tools that were used.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • **Who** caused the incident? • **What** happened? • **When** did the incident occur?

	• **Where** did the incident happen? • **Why** did the incident happen?
Additional notes	Include any additional thoughts, questions, or findings.

Need another journal entry template?

If you want to add more journal entries, please copy one of the tables above and paste it into the template to use for future entries.

Reflections/Notes:
Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?
Using Suricata was challenging at first since there is a lot of information to take in and understand at first. Once you learn and review all of the components of a rule then it is easier to digest and create the rules for packets passing through the interface.

Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed since taking this course?
My understanding on these topics have greatly increased due to the activities and labs that let me go more hands-on with incident detection and response.

Was there a specific tool or concept that you enjoyed the most? Why?
I enjoyed using VirusTotal to view information like flags for previously found files that have the potential of being malicious. Doing research and diving deeper into malicious files is interesting because you can find more information then you would find at the surface level.